向鸸鹋宣战

The Great Emu War



机枪为何没能解决鸸鹋危机?

英文原文

Around Campion, Western Australia, most farmers were First World War **veterans**, **settlers** placed by a government scheme on **marginal parcels** of **farmland**. They were **inexperienced growers**, and a quarter had already quit. In 1932, after drought, roughly 20,000 emus **swarmed** in from **arid** country **in flocks** and **trampled** the wheat **crops**.

The farmers' **plight** took a military turn. **In desperation**, a **delegation** of ex-soldiers **aired** their **grievances** and asked the Defence Minister for **machine-guns**. He agreed, sending not a **battalion** but a **detachment**: Major Meredith, an **artillery** officer, with two soldiers, two Lewis guns, and 10,000 rounds of **ammunition**. The **offensive** began on 2 November 1932.

At a dam, about a thousand birds approached an **ambush**, but a gun **jammed** after a dozen fell. The flocks broke **formation** into small, **agile** groups, **frustrating** each **tactical** plan, and a truck-mounted gun proved **futile**. Six days of **wasteful** firing spent 2,500 rounds on perhaps 50 to 200 birds, a **ludicrous** return. After **parliamentary** questions and press **ridicule**, an **embarrassing withdrawal** came on 8 November, though shooting restarted within days.

Meredith was recalled on 10 December. His **memo**'s **inventory** counted 986 kills from 9,860 rounds, a **ratio** of ten **bullets** to one bird. He **likened** the **resilient** birds' **toughness to** the **armour** of tanks. Five weeks of **warfare** had barely dented the **hardy** flocks' **endurance**.

Later **pleas** for **reinforcements** were refused, and **intervention gave way to** a **bounty sanctioned** by the government. This **payout** per bird gave farmers **compensation** and an **incentive** for **extermination**. Farmers claimed over 57,000 **payments** in six months of 1934, more than fifty-seven times Meredith's 986 kills.

中文译文

在西澳大利亚州坎皮恩一带，大多数农民是第一次世界大战的退伍军人，他们作为定居者，由政府计划安置在贫瘠的/边缘的小块土地上，以这些农地为生。他们是缺乏经验的种植者，已有四分之一的人放弃了土地。1932年，旱灾过后，约2万只鸸鹋成群地从干旱地区蜂拥而至，践踏了（指动物破坏）小麦庄稼。

农民的困境由此走向了军事手段。绝望之中，一个由退伍士兵组成的代表团公开表达了他们的不满/委屈，请求国防部长提供机枪。部长同意了，但派出的不是一个营，而是一支小分队：梅雷迪思少校，一名炮兵军官，带着两名士兵、两挺刘易斯机枪和1万发弹药。进攻于1932年11月2日展开。

在一处水坝，约一千只鸟靠近了埋伏/伏击范围，但打倒十来只后，一挺机枪就卡壳了。鸟群打乱了（它们自己的）队形，（它们）分成了灵活的小群体，挫败了每一个战术计划；装在卡车上的机枪也徒劳无功。六天的浪费的射击花费了/消耗了2,500发，只打死大约50至200只鸟，这是一个荒唐可笑的回报。在议会质询和报界嘲笑/嘲讽之后，一场尴尬的撤退发生在11月8日；不过没过几天，射击又重新开始了。

梅雷迪思于12月10日被召回。他在备忘录里开列的清单计数（显示），9,860发打死了986只，比例是十发子弹对一只鸟。他把这些耐打的鸟的坚韧比作坦克的装甲。五个星期的战事几乎没有削弱这些顽强的鸟群的耐受力/抗造力。

后来请求增援的恳求都遭到拒绝，干预转变为（让步于）政府批准的悬赏。这种按只计算的钱款支出（赏金）给了农民补偿，也成为彻底消灭鸸鹋的激励。农民在1934年的六个月里领取了5.7万多笔（赏金）支付，是梅雷迪思那986只战果的五十七倍多。

词汇与表达

veterans n.
退伍军人
First World War veterans

settlers n.
定居者

marginal adj.
贫瘠的/边缘的
on marginal parcels of farmland.

parcels n.
小块土地

farmland n.
农地

inexperienced adj.
缺乏经验的

growers n.
种植者

in flocks n.
成群地

swarmed v.
蜂拥而至

arid adj.
干旱
from arid country in flocks

trampled v.
践踏了（指动物破坏）

crops n.
庄稼

plight n.
困境
farmers' plight

In desperation n.
绝望之中

delegation n.
代表团
a delegation of ex-soldiers

aired v.
公开表达了

grievances n.
不满/委屈
their grievances

machine-guns n.
机枪

battalion n.
一个营

detachment n.
小分队
not a battalion but a detachment

artillery n.
炮兵

ammunition n.
弹药
10,000 rounds of ammunition.

offensive n.
进攻

ambush n.
埋伏/伏击范围
approached an ambush

jammed v.
卡壳了

formation n.
队形

agile adj.
灵活的
small, agile groups

frustrating v.
挫败了
frustrating each tactical plan

tactical adj.
战术

词汇与表达（续）

futile adj.
徒劳无功
proved futile.

wasteful adj.
浪费的

ludicrous adj.
荒唐可笑的
a ludicrous return.

parliamentary adj.
议会

ridicule n.
嘲笑/嘲讽

embarrassing adj.
尴尬的

withdrawal n.
撤退
an embarrassing withdrawal

memo n.
备忘录

inventory n.
清单

ratio n.
比例
a ratio of ten bullets to one bird.

bullets n.
子弹

likened to 表达
把……比作

resilient adj.
耐打的
the resilient birds' toughness

toughness n.
坚韧

armour n.
装甲

warfare n.
战事

hardy adj.
顽强的

endurance n.
耐受力/抗造力

pleas n.
恳求

reinforcements n.
增援
pleas for reinforcements

intervention n.
干预
intervention gave way to a bounty

gave way to phr. v.
转变为（让步于）
intervention gave way to a bounty

bounty n.
悬赏
a bounty sanctioned by the government.

sanctioned v.
批准

payout n.
钱款支出（赏金）

compensation n.
补偿
gave farmers compensation

incentive n.
激励
an incentive for extermination.

extermination n.
彻底消灭

payments n.
支付

文章简述

- 困境：1932年旱灾后，约两万只鸸鹋涌入西澳农田、践踏小麦；当地许多农户是退伍军人，向军方求助。
- 出兵：军方派一名少校和两名士兵，携两挺机枪、一万发子弹，试图射杀侵入农田的鸸鹋。
- 受挫：伏击时机枪卡壳，鸟群又分散成灵活小群，卡车上的机枪也没奏效；媒体嘲讽这场行动，议会提出质询。
- 撤军：部队一度撤离又恢复射击，约五周后被召回；报告登记消耗9860发子弹、击杀986只，平均约十发子弹一只，鸟患仍未解决。
- 转向：政府拒绝增援，改为农民每杀一只鸟就可申领一笔赏金；1934年半年内申领逾5.7万笔，按只计的数量远超军方登记战果。